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A Geographic Stroll Around the Horizon

By Rania Ghosn and El Hadi Jazairy

“We have an even bigger horizon ahead of us,” notes the major Brazilian oil company on its website after the 2007 discovery of mega-fields in the South Atlantic of Brazil. Located at some 200 km off the coast of Rio de Janeiro and at depths nearing 7,000 meters, such large oil fields promised a new petroleum horizon for the Brazilian economy. The subsequent economic development of the offshore required an expansive technological network of geological maps, oil concessionary blocks, transportation vectors, drilling axes, refinery ports, and labor nodes, all of which were necessary to transform the earth’s matter into circuits of capital.

Although geographically expansive and territorially inscribed, the domain of the offshore industry is often represented as a series of isolated platforms. In such worldview, the associated image of the rig, a fantastically insular technological object, severs the underpinning network of power and infrastructure. It occludes from representation the geographic scale of the industry and its embeddedness in mainland political structures perpetuating the imaginary of an “out-there” domain of resource extraction beyond environmental and economic accountability. Only succinctly, in the event of an oil-spill, does the offshore come to occupy public imaginaries. In Brazil, the 2001 sinking of *Petrobras-36* was the most publicized offshore visual owing in part to spectacular aerial photography. The images of both the exceptional megastructure and of the environmental “accident” are thus part of the oil valuation regime. The techniques of visual imaging, or the “technologies of the visible,” Peter Galison and Caroline Jones advance, are the means by which the event of the disaster becomes manifest. Reflecting on the “spillcam” coverage of the 2010 Deepwater Horizon spill disaster,

Galison and Jones argue that the iconic and unprecedented visual images of the oil spill offered a continuing announcement of our ability to picture but not stop the flow, soliciting the pragmatic necessity of thinking beyond the surface images.¹

The project reclaims the offshore to urban political consciousness from within the project of representation by deploying the horizon as a geographic aesthetic construct. Literally, “earth-writing” from the Greek *geo* (earth) and *graphia* (writing), such practice of making geographies involves the coupled undertakings of “writing about,” projecting or representing the earth and also “writing,” marking, forming or presenting again a world. It responds to a condition in which designers are increasingly compelled to tackle concerns, such as energy, that had been confined to the domains of engineering, ecology, or regional planning. Such issues of infrastructure, technology, and policy now invite articulation through design and require a re-examination of tools to formalize their attributes.² The geographic project opens thus a range of aesthetic and political regimes for design.

A Geographic Stroll Around the Horizon counters the abstraction of the offshore into a zone of extractive fantasies by expanding the spatial and cognitive imaginary of the city of Rio de Janeiro into its ocean-hinterland. In *The Image of the City* (1960), Kevin Lynch emphasized the relations of mobility, perception, and legibility for the spatial reorientation of people in the alienated space of the city as well as within the urban totality. The project extends Lynch’s framework to the scale of the geographic. To expand the domain of the lived and perceived, ten of Rio’s most iconic sites, such as Estádio do Maracanã, Pão de Açúcar, Aqueduto da Carioca and Favela-Bairro, are projected into a linear archipelago deployed between the coast and the oil offshore. Such monuments stand for the Rio, they function synecdochally to figure the city in the extractive urban hinterland. The distance between these islands is defined in relation to the optics of vision associated with the horizon. Set at a distance of 4.7 kilometers for an observer standing on the Earth’s surface, the horizon is a historically significant construct as it represents the maximum range of perception, communication and knowledge.

Ten sites extracted from Rio into its offshore hinterland.

1. Catedral Metropolitana de São Sebastião
2. Estádio do Maracanã
3. Aterro do Flamengo
4. Praia de Copacabana
5. Favela Bairro
6. Sambadrome Marquês de Sapucaí
7. Morro de Corcovado
8. Pão de Açúcar
9. Aqueduto da Carioca

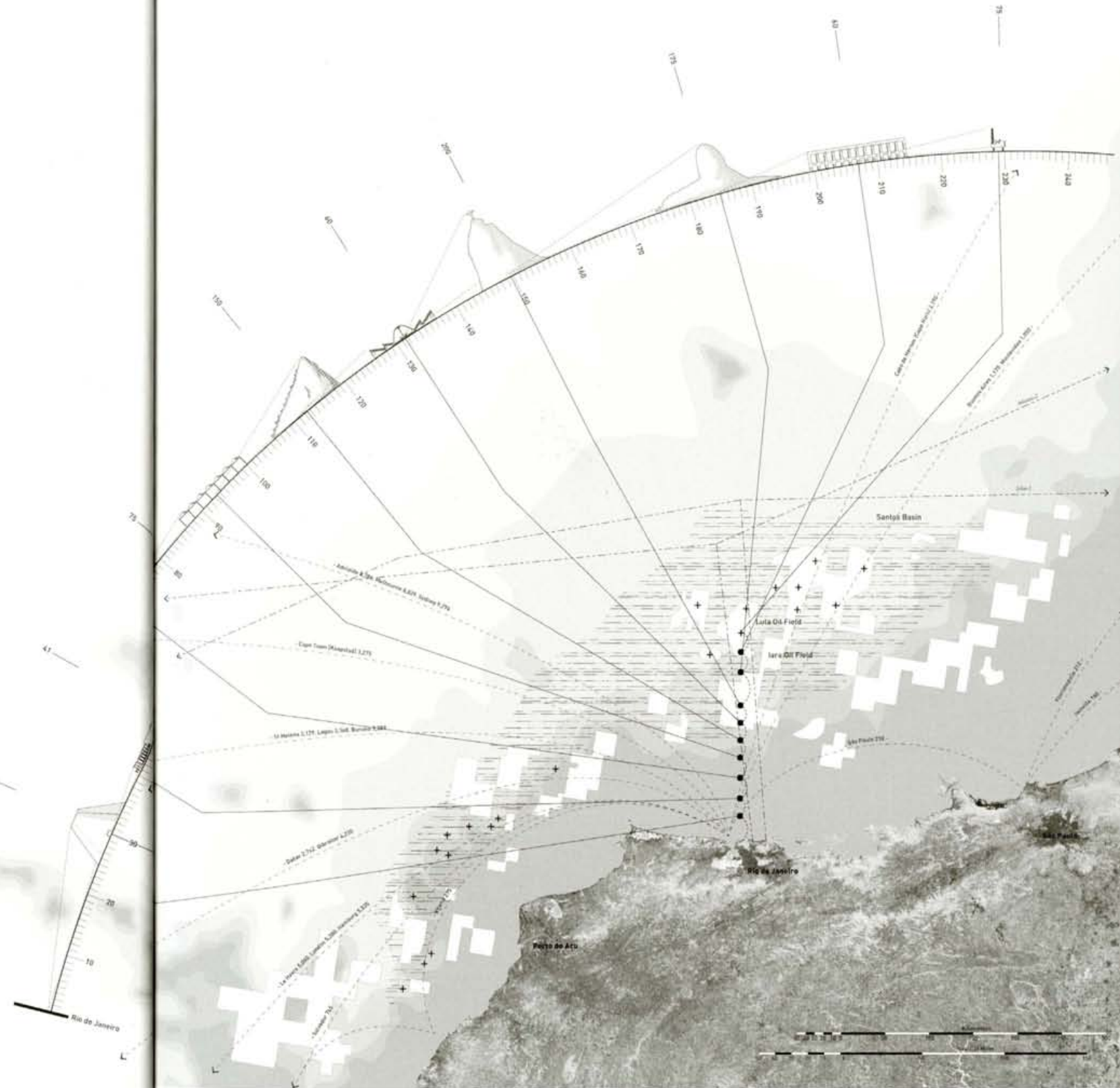


Axonometries of the Ten Sites

Beyond a mere shift in scale, being-in-the-ocean recuperates a geographic aesthetic away from the prevailing managerial pragmatism of mapping logistics. In *The Horizon: A History of Our Infinite Longing*, Didier Maleuvre explores the fascination with

the horizon through a vast history of cultural artifacts that “draw the line between the known and the unknowable.”²⁴ Drawing on *Weltlandschaft*, the 16th century Dutch tradition of the “world landscape,” this project employs a bird’s eye view with

a high horizon line as though the viewer is peering out over the landscape from above. Against a background defined by the curvature of the earth, the assemblage of geographic objects features the carnival parade in the foreground, filled with revel-

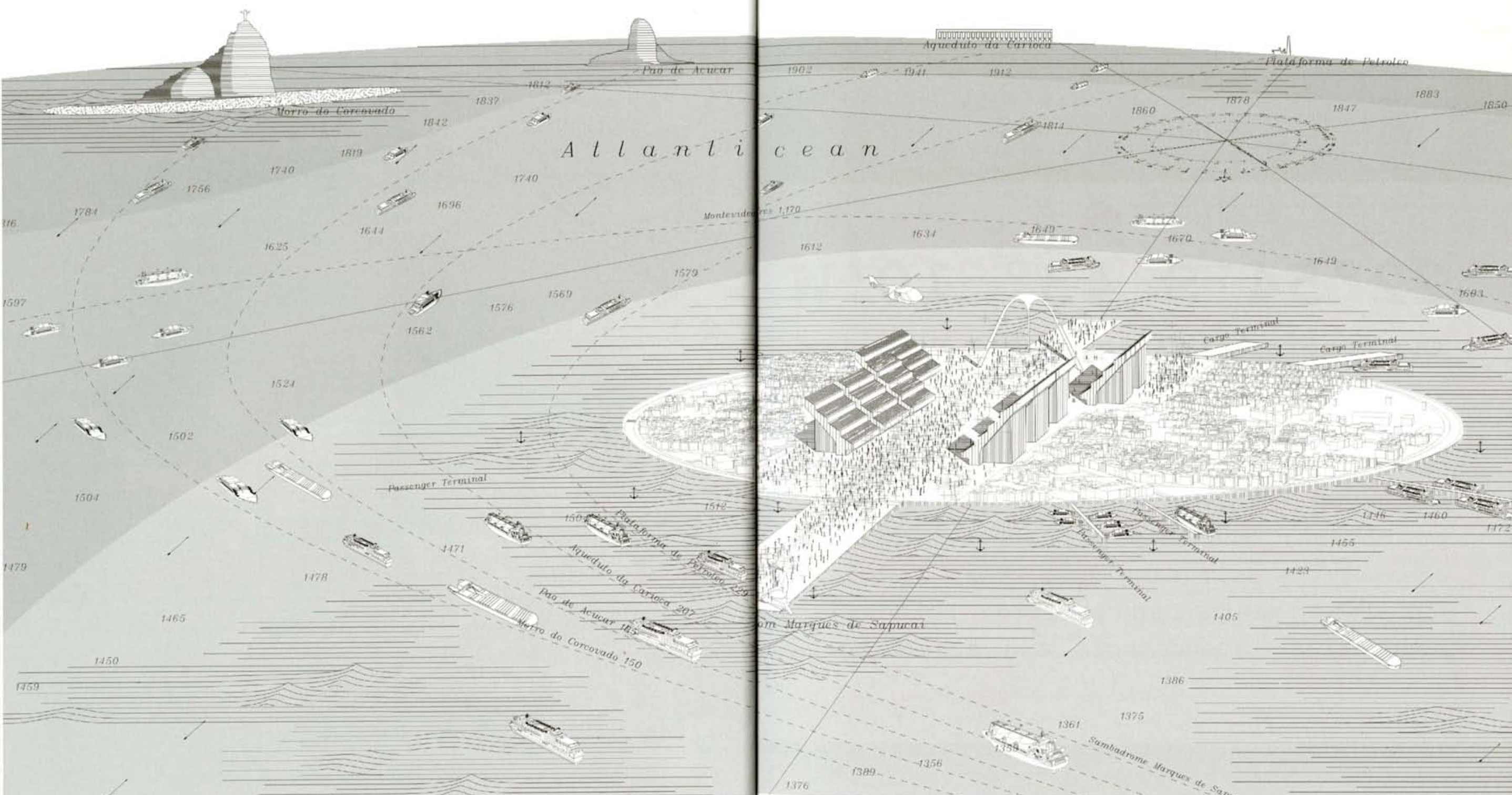


ers, floats and adornments from numerous samba schools. The project draws as well on Victor Pimstein's HORIZON 35 series (2008), which investigates the position of the line where water and sky meet as well as the variations in blueness of each.

In a series of portrait shots, the ten proposed geographic silhouettes are figured against a high horizon and changing skies.

The reclaimed geographic constellation solicits new subjectivities and experi-

ences around the blue horizon. "The sea gives us the idea of the indefinite, the unlimited, and infinite," observes Ben-Artzi in relation to the Mediterranean, "and in feeling his own infinite in that Infinite, man is stimulated and emboldened to



World picture of the offshore

stretch beyond the limited.¹⁵ The newly inhabited sea territory forms a wandering surface for the collective. Around sunset, at the moment when the neon-pink sun slips below the horizon, everyone stops, stands and claps: a nightly salute to city,

sea and sky. Such Aristotelians celebrate that philosophy begins in wonder, and that to wander beyond the horizon—the urge to know beyond the conceivable—is itself the engine of the polis and civic life.

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Notes

1. Peter Galison and Caroline Jones, "Unknown Quantities," *Artforum* XLIX (2010): 49–51.
2. The authors are founding editors of the Harvard GSD *New Geographies* journal and acknowledge Hashim Sarkis for his mentorship and deep insights throughout. See Hashim Sarkis, "The World According to Architecture," *New Geographies* 4.

3. *Scales of the Earth*, ed. El Hadi Jazairy (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2011).
4. Kevin Lynch, *The Image of the City* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1960).
5. Didier Malgouyres, *The Horizon: A History of Our Infinite Longing* (University of California Press, 2011), 1.
6. Youssef Ben-Artzi, "The Idea of a Mediterranean Region in Nineteenth- to Mid-Twentieth-Century German Geography," *Mediterranean Historical Review* (2004): 2–13, 6.

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